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Essay 1

Aligning Purpose, Identity, and Work: An Analysis of Modern Logic

Many people in today's world feel pressured to select a career that is both financially stable and reflects their values and identity. **This modern Western cultural belief that careers should reflect one's identity alters how people think about work, fulfillment, and achievement.** The article "Aligning Your Career With Your Life Purpose" (author unknown) speaks on this topic by **urging readers to reevaluate their goals, especially since its publication date is January 3rd**, three days after New Year's. The article targets readers who feel uncertain about their career path and are seeking direction. Its genre as an online website **makes it accessible** to young adults who are seeking purpose. The author provides advice and encouragement to persuade readers to focus on their values and find careers that align with their purpose. **By drawing on** Western cultural assumptions about identity, fulfillment, and purpose, the article creates a persuasive argument and encourages young adults to pursue a purpose-driven career that aligns with their personal values.

In a culture where young people are taught to "find themselves" before picking a career, they must first internally discover their purpose through reflection and personal values. **This cultural expectation supports the article's argument that people should choose their purpose over financial gain.** The article's message is persuasive through its use of powerful

Western cultural assumptions about self-expression, identity, and achievement. The article expands on this cultural expectation through a detailed explanation of how purpose is found:

Your life purpose is the intersection of your passions, skills, values, and the meaningful impact you want to make. Before aligning your career with purpose, you need career clarity on what your unique purpose actually is. This isn't about finding some cosmic destiny written in the stars. Purpose emerges from honest self-exploration—asking what activities make you come alive, what values matter most, and what contribution you feel called to make. Understanding how to find your life purpose is the foundation for designing a meaningful career. (“Aligning Your Career”)

The definition that the author creates is deeply engraved into the Western belief that purpose is **discovered internally, rather than given externally. It suggests that fulfillment needs to come from a career—something we spend so much of our lives performing—that aligns with their values and personal beliefs.** This logic appeals to many young adults, such as myself, who are enrolled in college and are stressed to find the perfect major choice. We all have a feeling of anxiety about the decision because of the fear that we may pick incorrectly and lose out on a bigger paycheck.

Society teaches that work should be a source of personal fulfillment, yet many people end up in a career that clashes with their values, causing social pressure and a disconnect from their work. **Another cultural assumption that the article relies on is the belief that work should be fulfilling rather than merely a source of income.** The author speaks from their experience and explains that:

Your values are the non-negotiables that guide your decisions and define what matters most. When your career conflicts with your core values, you'll feel drained and disconnected. When it aligns, work energizes you. A values based career creates the foundation for job satisfaction and purpose. ("Aligning Your Career")

This quote reflects on the modern expectation that work should be energizing, rather than exhausting. In many Western cultures, especially among younger adults, a job is not seen as just a paycheck, but a way to present one's own experience, values, and personality in an environment. **This is visible in today's internship market, where companies seek individuals who meet the social and skill requirements.** Companies now look to hire interns and train them into employees rather than old-fashioned hiring approaches. This means that not only do individuals need to have a good resume and cover letter, but they also need to get along with the other staff, complete the work promptly, and be a people person in order to be appreciated and hired on. The article helps individuals meet these expectations by encouraging them to follow their personality and find a career that satisfies them. This logic validates the emotional importance in the workspace and how people who feel unfulfilled in their current roles may not perform as well as individuals who are doing what they love. It reassures the audience that their current dissatisfaction should not be seen as a failure but as a sign that their work does not align with their true values.

Many people grow up believing that hard work and patience will eventually lead to success. To reassure readers who are intimidated by changing careers, the author explains the importance of career development:

Purpose-aligned careers are built through deliberate, strategic action. Transitioning from your current career to find meaningful work aligned with your purpose may

feel daunting. The gap between where you are and where you want to be can seem enormous. But career alignment strategies and purpose driven career development make closing this gap entirely possible.

(“Aligning Your Career”)

The logic appeals to the readers who may feel overwhelmed by the idea of switching majors or careers, as they think it may be too much for them to shift their entire life overnight. Instead of expecting a dramatic jump into the unknown, the author suggests that consistent small steps are the best approach to becoming successful in your own way that aligns with your life goal. **This logic originates from the Western cultural assumption that disciplined effort allows individuals to control their own destiny.** It reassures the young readers once again that they do not need to abandon their current situation in search of a new identity, but rather need to assess and conquer at their own pace. For many young adults, like myself, this message is comforting because it reminds young readers that we all still have time to make mistakes and grow before settling down in our careers. Purpose is not something that comes easily, nor is it something that comes instantly, but it's something that develops over time through patience, perseverance, and courage.

Critics may argue, however, that finding a purpose-driven career is a privilege that not everyone is lucky enough to achieve. **For individuals facing financial pressure and needing to support their family, prioritizing a high-paying career is more realistic in the short term.** Therefore, they may argue that this idea of pursuing a person's “dream job” overlooks the realistic economic factor that many people face. **They may also argue that aligning work with personal values is unrealistic for those who can not afford to take a risk due to finances, age, or lack of education.** While this perspective is valid, the article is targeted towards

individuals who are willing to take a risk and who are willing to gain a higher level of education to achieve their long-term goals and fulfill their dreams. For these young adults, the pursuit and “grind” towards a better life may seem unrealistic and just another New Year’s Resolution; however, if they stay consistent and patient, then they are destined to succeed.

Persuasion can be seen throughout the online website article “Aligning Your Career With Your Life Purpose” (author unknown) because it draws ideas from powerful Western cultural assumptions about identity, fulfillment, and purpose to build logic and appeal to the target audience. The article’s focus on aligning one’s work towards one’s purpose and personal values is a very compelling argument that encourages individuals to pursue their dreams and reflect on their core values. Published on January 3rd, the rhetorical situation and logical structure work together to build a message that young adults, including myself, can relate to. In conclusion, the article clearly speaks to people who are not just searching for a career but a purpose. **It reassures readers that with sustained and disciplined work, they can eventually achieve fulfillment by aligning their work with their values.** The message is clear and motivating, leading to a sense of hope for all of those who are struggling to push past the societal pressures of choosing a career.

Work Cited

“Aligning Your Career with Your Life Purpose.” Empower Process, 3 Jan. 2026,
<https://empowerprocess.com/purpose/aligning-your-career-with-your-life-purpose/>